



EXHIBITION ▼

New Tides

Ishara House opens in Kochi with *AMPHIBIAN AESTHETICS*, a cross-continental inquiry into fluid lives, climate precarity and coexistence



A CHURN OF HOPE AND DOOM
Clockwise from top left: Dima Srouji's *A Crack in the Water Followed by Return* (recycled metal and soil); *Dream ka Tuka*; Shanvin's *In, Between* (multi-media)

Undoubtedly, the climate crisis is the conversation of the hour. It's the subject that's driving dialogues not only in parliaments and think tanks, but also in the arts, as artists respond to the uncertainties of our times. In Kochi, Ishara Art Foundation marks the opening of Ishara House with *Amphibian Aesthetics*, an exhibition that emerges from the urgencies of precarity in the Anthropocene—climate collapse, displacement, extinction and hyper-capital.

Curated by the House's artistic director Riyas Komu—also the co-founder of Aazhi Archives, ideator of the Kochi-Muziris Biennale and co-founder of the Kochi Biennale Foundation—the show brings together 12 artists and collectives from South Asia, West Asia and Europe, reflecting on the urgencies afflicting the planet, suggesting multiple modes of being.

The exhibit positions Kerala's oceanic histories of migration, trade and climatic shifts as both sites of possibility and crisis

"[The exhibition] was an attempt to reverse the gaze and shift positions, to start looking at the land from the fluid, shifting point of view of the sea, to use the sea not as a metaphor but a whole new way of looking at life and the world," says Komu.

The roster of artists on display has Appupen, CAAS Collective (Dr Susmita Mohanty, Rohini Devasher, Sue Fairburn and Barbara Imhof), Dima Srouji, Michelangelo Pistoletto, Midhun Mohan, Rami Farook, Ratheesh T., Kabir Project (Shabnam Virmani, Anisha Baid and Smriti Chanchani), Shanvin Sixtous, Shilpa Gupta, White Balance and Zahir Mirza—a motley crew of illustrators, painters, and filmmakers. The thought behind this cast stemmed from the fact that anything 'amphibious' is not limited to a singular idiom of expression.

"The artists and their works in this show explore such amphibious trajectories and possibilities at different scales and dimensions, through varied modes and mediums," says Komu

Drawing on past artistic engagements with Kerala's oceanic histories — migration, trade and climatic shifts — *Amphibian Aesthetics* postures these liaisons as spaces of crisis as much as possibility. By centring water's agency and multispecies coexistence, the show invites multi-sited, multimodal ways of imagining collective futures. Komu calls Kerala "not a place, but a state of mind," as a land that was "always open to the world" with a long and tumultuous history of romance with the sea. For him, the most striking part of the show is how its site, Kochi, and its "deep sedimented histories" became a crucial collaborator to bring the project to life. ■

—Arshia

The exhibition is on till Mar. 31